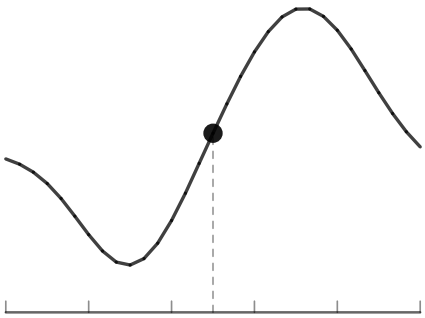
Tuckman’s Stages of Group Development

Emergence of passive-aggressive interactions in code reviews, backchannel factionalism regarding technical stack choices, hesitation in public architecture discussions, and defensive justifications for pull request rejections.



SCHEMATIC

Five-stage developmental arc

T01

Tuckman’s Stages of Group Development

MANAGER SCRIPT

Forming-to-Storming Facilitation

"The team has established basic communication channels, but distinct friction exists regarding our technical architectural decisions. This tension is normal and expected. During this retrospective, each team member will surface one unspoken friction point regarding current engineering practices. The objective is to bring latent technical divergence to light so standardized conventions can be codified."

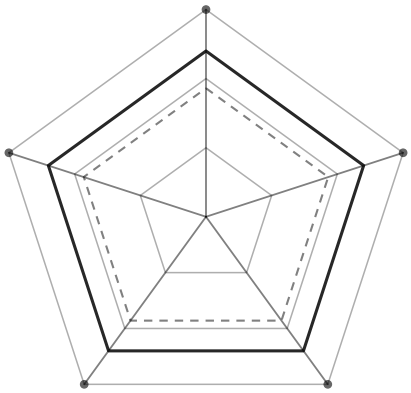
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do reviews apply the agreed linter and charter rather than ideology?
- Are architecture disputes settled in open RFCs within forty-eight hours?

Source: Bruce W. Tuckman (1965). *Developmental Sequence in Small Groups.* Psychological Bulletin.
Source: Bruce W. Tuckman & Mary Ann C. Jensen (1977). *Stages of Small-Group Development Revisited.* Group & Organization Studies.

Hackman's Five Conditions for Team Effectiveness

Diffuse team boundaries where individuals belong to multiple conflicting squads, shifting sprint targets resulting in cynicism, and inadequate CI/CD tooling or access privileges preventing work execution.



SCHEMATIC

Five-conditions radar

T02

Hackman’s Five Conditions for Team Effectiveness

MANAGER SCRIPT

Structural Boundary Delineation

"Current sprint throughput indicates an ambiguous distribution of team capacity. We will delineate our boundary conditions. The team requires explicit definition: who is dedicated exclusively to this deliverable, what non-negotiable metric dictates success for this release, and what external dependencies lack operational support from engineering management?"

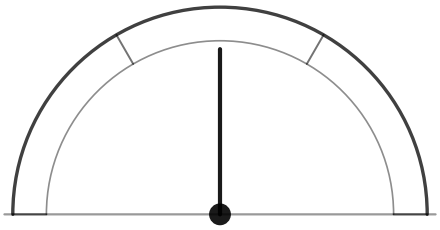
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Does every contributor name one squad that owns their capacity?
- Did the sprint goal stay unchanged across the fourteen-day interval?

Source: J. Richard Hackman (2002). *Leading Teams: Setting the Stage for Great Performances.* Harvard Business School Press.

Team Charters & Social Contracts

Chronic tardiness to daily standups, uneven distribution of code review workloads, ambiguous escalation pathways during production outages, and mismatched expectations surrounding work hours.



SCHEMATIC

Agreement-formality continuum

T03

Team Charters & Social Contracts

MANAGER SCRIPT

Charter Realignment

"Our current operational friction stems from implicit, unverified expectations around availability and code reviews. We are establishing an explicit social contract in our team repository. The charter will document core working hours, review turnaround expectations, and escalation paths. If an operational practice is not committed to the Markdown charter, it cannot be enforced."

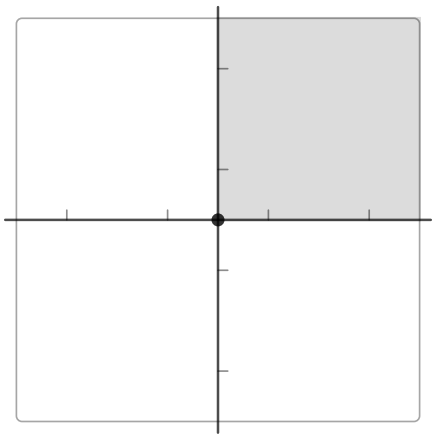
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do review turnarounds meet the turnaround the charter states?
- Do retrospectives cite charter commitments when they assess delays?

Source: John E. Mathieu & Tammy L. Rapp (2009). *Laying the Foundation for Successful Team Performance Trajectories: The Roles of Team Charters and Performance Strategies.* Journal of Applied Psychology.

RACI vs. DACI Decision & Responsibility Allocation Matrices

Architectural paralysis where pull requests languish indefinitely awaiting sign-off; multi-party ownership where "everyone owns, hence nobody owns" critical service components; executive overrides late in deployment phases.



SCHEMATIC

Decision-rights quadrant

T04

RACI vs. DACI Decision & Responsibility Allocation Matrices

MANAGER SCRIPT

DACI Escalation

"This architectural initiative has halted due to diffuse decision rights. We are adopting a DACI framework for this deliverable. Contributor A is designated the Driver; Principal Engineer B is the sole Approver; domain specialists C and D are Contributors; the remaining squad members are Informed. The Driver coordinates input, and the Approver will deliver a binding technical decision by Thursday at 15:00 UTC."

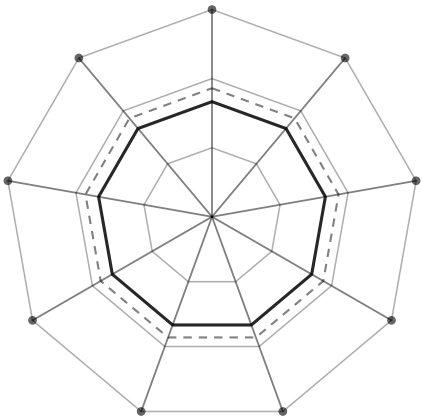
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did one named Approver sign off, without a second committee review?
- Did uninformed stakeholders stay out of the release-blocking path?

Source: Project Management Institute (2017). *A Guide to the Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBOK Guide)*. Project Management Institute.

Belbin Team Inventory (Team Roles Theory)

Engineering initiatives stall during final verification because the team lacks execution-oriented focus, or innovative architecture proposals are immediately dismissed due to an excess of risk-averse Monitor-Evaluators.



SCHEMATIC

Nine-role radar

T05

Belbin Team Inventory (Team Roles Theory)

MANAGER SCRIPT

Role Composition Calibration

"An evaluation of our recent delivery cycles reveals a gap between architectural ideation and deliverable hardening. The team possesses exceptional 'Plant' and 'Monitor-Evaluator' capabilities, yet lacks consistent 'Completer-Finisher' behaviors. For the upcoming cycle, Contributor X will drive the edge-case validation and deployment checklist."

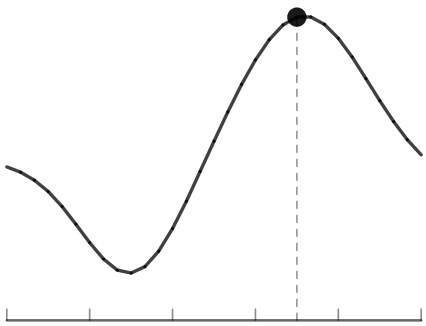
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Have missed regression bugs at deploy verification fallen?
- Do post-mortems show work spread across planning, design and execution?

Source: R. Meredith Belbin (1981). *Management Teams: Why They Succeed or Fail.* Heinemann.

Katzenbach & Smith’s Team Performance Curve

The squad calls itself a team but functions as individual silos with isolated backlogs; collective output is lower than individual contributions; cynicism emerges concerning shared meetings.



SCHEMATIC

Team-performance arc

T06

Katzenbach & Smith's Team Performance Curve

MANAGER SCRIPT

Pseudo-Team Intervention

"We currently operate as a pseudo-team: individual developers deliver isolated tickets, yet we absorb the meeting overhead of a collective unit without reaping collaborative output. We must choose: either decouple our tasks into discrete individual streams or define a single shared operational deliverable for which we are mutually accountable."

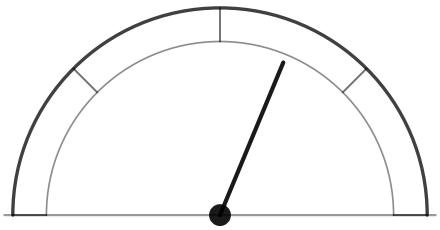
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Is the sprint goal one shared deliverable, not unrelated tickets?
- Do pairing sessions form on their own to clear pipeline blocks?

Source: Jon R. Katzenbach & Douglas K. Smith (1993). *The Wisdom of Teams: Creating the High-Performance Organization.* Harvard Business School Press.

Dunbar’s Number & Team Topologies (Two-Pizza Teams)

Standup meetings exceed twenty minutes; Slack channels become unmanageably noisy; engineers report feeling detached from end-to-end user impact; pull request review requests are routinely ignored due to notification overload.



SCHEMATIC

Team-size continuum

T07

Dunbar’s Number & Team Topologies (Two-Pizza Teams)

MANAGER SCRIPT

Decoupling & Boundary Definition

"The current team has surpassed nine contributors, resulting in communication overhead and slowed delivery. In accordance with Team Topologies, we will split this unit into two Stream-Aligned Teams with an internal Platform API boundary. Each unit will maintain autonomous ownership of their deployable service boundary."

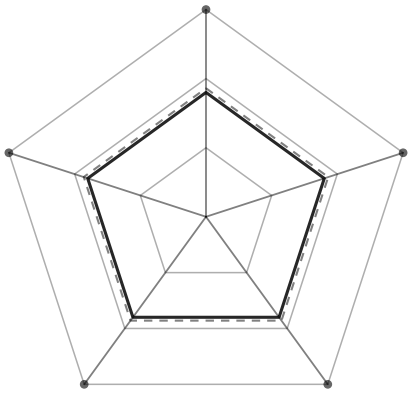
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did standups fall below ten minutes on average?
- Did cross-team talk move to API contracts and async requests?

Source: Robin I. M. Dunbar (1992). *Neocortex Size as a Constraint on Group Size in Primates.* Journal of Human Evolution.
Source: Matthew Skelton & Manuel Pais (2019). *Team Topologies: Organizing Business and Technology Teams for Fast Flow.* IT Revolution Press.

Social Interdependence Theory & Cohesion

Engineers refuse to pick up unassigned bugs or documentation tickets; individual metrics (such as committed lines of code or ticket closure counts) are prioritized over system delivery; sprint goals fail despite high individual velocity.



SCHEMATIC

Cohesion-profile radar

T08

Social Interdependence Theory & Cohesion

MANAGER SCRIPT

Interdependence Restructuring

"Our current operational dynamic incentivizes individual velocity over squad delivery, which compromises sprint completion. Effective immediately, our evaluation criteria hinge exclusively on shared service health: ticket throughput is irrelevant if the collective staging build remains red. Contributor velocity metrics are deprecated in favor of squad cycle time."

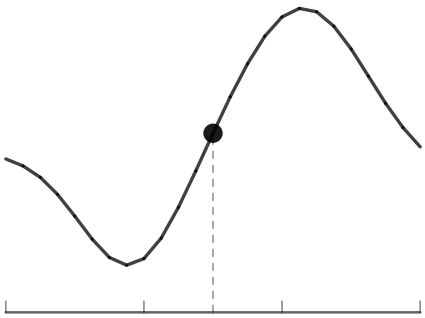
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did people pair on blocked high-priority tickets outside their domain?
- Was unowned triage and documentation picked up without a manager?

Source: Morton Deutsch (1949). *A Theory of Co-operation and Competition.* Human Relations.
Source: David W. Johnson & Roger T. Johnson (1989). *Cooperation and Competition: Theory and Research.* Interaction Book Company.

Gersick’s Punctuated Equilibrium Model

Prolonged lack of urgency during the initial 40% of a project timeline, followed by an abrupt panic approaching the midpoint; initial assumptions about system complexity prove false.



SCHEMATIC

Punctuated-equilibrium arc

T09

Gersick’s Punctuated Equilibrium Model

MANAGER SCRIPT

Midpoint Reset

"We have reached the calendar midpoint of this quarterly release. Gersick's punctuated equilibrium research demonstrates that now is the empirical inflection point: our early architectural assumptions must be adapted based on what we have observed so far. We will review our scope today, prune non-essential secondary features, and solidify our final delivery baseline."

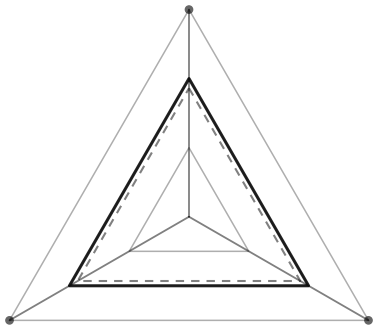
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the team prune non-viable requirements after the midpoint?
- Did execution velocity rise after the midpoint alignment session?

Source: Connie J. G. Gersick (1988). *Time and Transition in Work Teams: Toward a New Model of Group Development.* Administrative Science Quarterly.

Ancona & Caldwell's Boundary Spanning Framework

The engineering team delivers a technically sophisticated system that product managers or operations teams reject; the squad reports feeling blindsided by corporate strategic shifts or downstream system migrations.



SCHEMATIC

Boundary-spanning radar

T10

Ancona & Caldwell's Boundary Spanning Framework

MANAGER SCRIPT

External Engagement Mandate

"Our internal execution is robust, but we are isolated from dependent domain changes. We are establishing formal boundary-spanning roles: Contributor A will operate as the Ambassador to the Infrastructure group; Contributor B will handle Task Coordination with the Product Strategy team. We will review external dependencies weekly in our architecture forum."

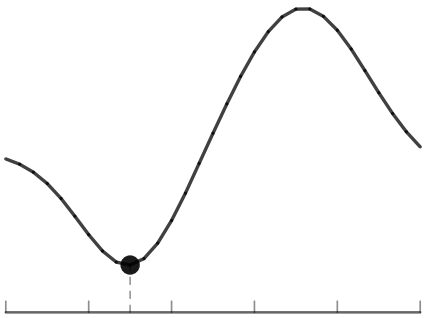
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Were downstream API breaking changes flagged five days before freeze?
- Did upstream alignment prevent mid-sprint requirement changes?

Source: Deborah G. Ancona & David F. Caldwell (1992). *Bridging the Boundary: External Activity and Performance in Organizational Teams.* Administrative Science Quarterly.

Cog’s Ladder of Group Development

Team members engage in excessive politeness while privately dissenting; passive non-compliance occurs during feature planning; informal power struggles derail retrospective agendas.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder-of-group-development arc

T11

Cog’s Ladder of Group Development

MANAGER SCRIPT

Power Distribution Facilitation

"Our retrospective observations show that the team remains constrained by polite deference, which masks genuine operational disagreements. We need to formalize technical ownership. We will explicitly clarify the distribution of technical authority across frontend, backend, and data storage systems to resolve latent conflicts."

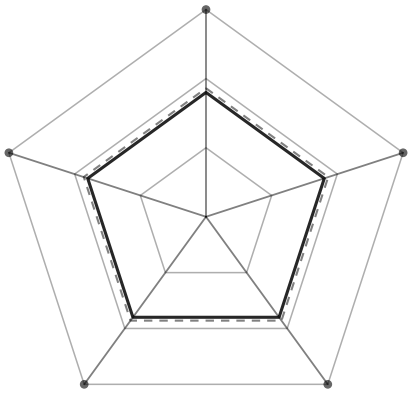
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do engineers debate design trade-offs in RFCs without a manager?
- Has polite disengagement become direct public technical debate?

Source: George O. Charrier (1972). *Cog's Ladder: A Model of Group Growth.* SAM Advanced Management Journal.

Edmondson’s Psychological Safety Diagnostic

Zero production errors or failures recorded over extended periods; silence in retrospectives; juniors hesitating to question senior architectural assumptions; sudden discovery of systemic defects near release deadlines.



SCHEMATIC

Five-axis safety radar

T12

Edmondson’s Psychological Safety Diagnostic

MANAGER SCRIPT

Vulnerability Normalization

"Looking through our retro notes, we have not logged a single system failure or mistake in three sprints. In distributed software engineering, silence is not indicative of perfection; it is a leading indicator of risk aversion. As engineering lead, I made an architectural miscalculation on the caching layer last week that elevated latency. I am opening the floor: what system failures or uncertainties are currently remaining unaddressed?"

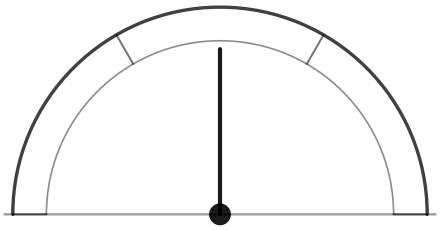
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do all members answer no to 'a mistake here is held against you'?
- Did a junior engineer challenge a senior's pull request in public?

Source: Amy C. Edmondson (1999). *Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams.* Administrative Science Quarterly.

Westrum Organizational Culture Typology

"Messengers are shot" when incidents occur; cross-functional silos refuse to share deployment data; failures result in bureaucratic procedure expansions rather than system automation.



SCHEMATIC

Culture continuum

T13

Westrum Organizational Culture Typology

MANAGER SCRIPT

Generative Inquiry Protocol

"The incident review for the recent outage showed that information was withheld due to fear of blame. In this engineering unit, failure is treated as systemic diagnostic data, not personal error. We will trace the socio-technical conditions that allowed this configuration error to deploy without human gatekeeping."

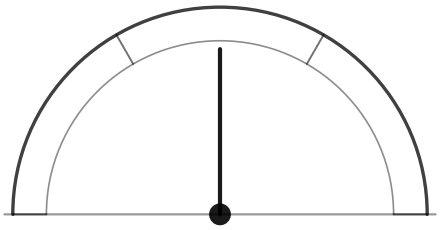
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do incident notices go public within fifteen minutes, unfiltered?
- Do fixes come from linters and CI gates, not manual sign-off?

Source: Ron Westrum (2004). *A Typology of Organisational Cultures.* Quality and Safety in Health Care.

Coyle’s Vulnerability Loop & Belonging Cues

Team members maintain an illusion of effortless competence; defensive pushback occurs when code quality concerns are flagged; isolationism during complex debugging sessions.



SCHEMATIC

Trust-signal continuum

T14

Coyle’s Vulnerability Loop & Belonging Cues

MANAGER SCRIPT

Vulnerability Signal Initiation

"I reviewed the performance profile of our core event broker. I do not have a working model for why this latency spike is happening under load. I need technical help. Who can pair with me to audit this trace and find where my mental model broke down?"

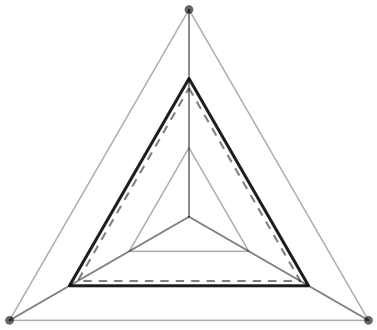
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did someone say 'I don't understand this component' and find a pair?
- Have reviews become learning dialogues, not defensive negotiation?

Source: Daniel Coyle (2018). *The Culture Code: The Secrets of Highly Successful Groups.* Bantam Books.

Maister, Green & Galford's Trust Equation

High individual technical brilliance accompanied by peer distrust; suspicion regarding team members playing political games for promotions; withholding help to secure personal velocity metrics.



SCHEMATIC

Trust-equation radar

T15

Maister, Green & Galford's Trust Equation

MANAGER SCRIPT

Self-Orientation Calibration

"Our code reviews and technical roadmap planning show high Credibility and Reliability, but trust is being degraded by perceived high Self-Orientation. When engineers prioritize their individual performance metrics over team support, collaborative throughput suffers. We will recalibrate sprint evaluations to prioritize cross-functional enablement."

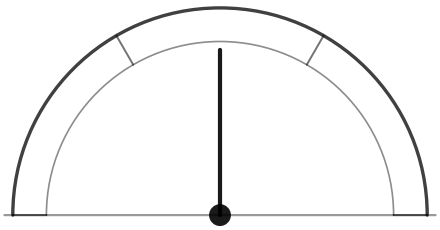
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did people unblock peers' reviews before their own secondary work?
- Did roadmaps carry shared maintenance without executive friction?

Source: David H. Maister, Charles H. Green & Robert M. Galford (2000). *The Trusted Advisor.* The Free Press.

Schein’s Three Levels of Organizational Culture

The company claims to value "engineering quality" (espoused value), but rewards engineers who cut tests to meet aggressive dates (underlying assumption); team handbooks celebrate work-life balance while managers ping engineers late at night.



SCHEMATIC

Three-level culture continuum

T16

Schein’s Three Levels of Organizational Culture

MANAGER SCRIPT

Cultural Incongruence Audit

"Our stated value is 'test-driven stability,' but our operational reality is that engineers who skip unit testing to hit dates are praised, while those fixing technical debt are questioned. We are addressing this discrepancy. We will freeze new feature development for this sprint to address structural technical debt."

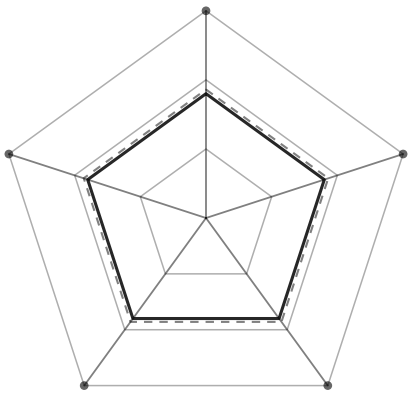
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Does sprint planning fund bug and debt work without pushback?
- Are after-hours messages stopped or flagged non-urgent?

Source: Edgar H. Schein (1985). *Organizational Culture and Leadership.* Jossey-Bass.

Google’s Project Aristotle Normative Architecture

Two senior engineers dominate 80% of standup and retrospective discussions; quieter developers do not participate; commitments made during sprint planning routinely drop without notice.



SCHEMATIC

Five-norm safety radar

T17

Google's Project Aristotle Normative Architecture

MANAGER SCRIPT

Conversational Equalization

"Our retrospective interaction metrics show unbalanced participation. Moving forward, we will implement structured turn-taking for architectural RFC reviews. Each participant will have two minutes of uninterrupted time to contribute before open floor debate begins. We will start with those who have contributed the least during the current session."

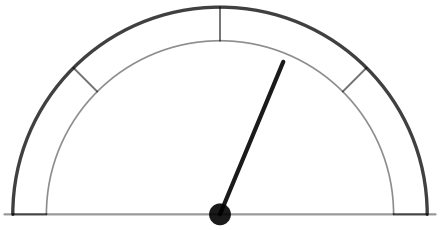
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did everyone speak at least once in planning and retrospective?
- Is speaking time spreading more evenly across the squad?

Google People Analytics, Project Aristotle (2012-2015); the study is internal and no primary report was published. Source: Charles Duhigg (2016). *What Google Learned From Its Quest to Build the Perfect Team.* The New York Times Magazine.

Clark’s Four Stages of Psychological Safety

The team tolerates questions (Learner Safety) and executes tasks (Contributor Safety), but immediately shuts down challenges to legacy code patterns or senior leadership roadmaps (lack of Challenger Safety).



SCHEMATIC

Four-stage safety continuum

T18

Clark’s Four Stages of Psychological Safety

MANAGER SCRIPT

Challenger Safety Facilitation

"The squad has proven its execution capability, but we have stopped innovating our internal architectural primitives. I am challenging this team to challenge the current design. In this meeting, each developer will identify one practice in our deployment pipeline that should be dismantled. The most disruptive, valid critique will be prioritized."

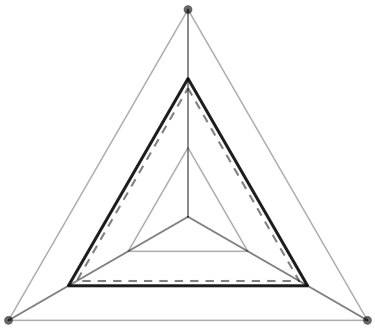
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the team argue an RFC that challenges legacy patterns?
- Did juniors disagree with leadership without friction?

Source: Timothy R. Clark (2020). *The 4 Stages of Psychological Safety: Defining the Path to Inclusion and Innovation.* Berrett-Koehler.

Mayer, Davis & Schoorman's Integrative Model of Trust

Developers trust a colleague's technical competence (Ability), but suspect they will claim exclusive credit for a joint project (low Benevolence), or catch them fabricating testing coverage numbers (low Integrity).



SCHEMATIC

Integrative-trust radar

T19

Mayer, Davis & Schoorman's Integrative Model of Trust

MANAGER SCRIPT

Integrity & Benevolence Alignment

"We have high technical competence in our squad, but our cross-functional alignment is fragile. For our code-sharing initiative to work, we need full transparency. We will conduct pair-programming rotations across the service layer to eliminate silos and verify that code ownership remains shared."

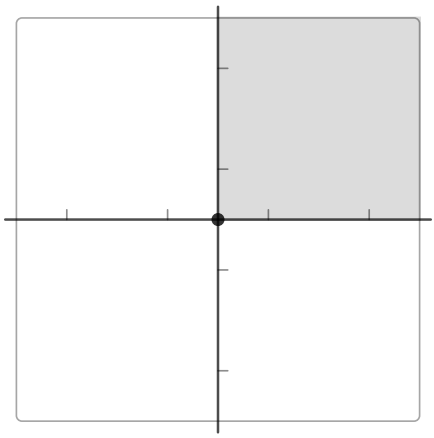
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did reviews explain their criticism rather than dismiss it?
- Are wins and merges credited to both pairing partners?

Source: Roger C. Mayer, James H. Davis & F. David Schoorman (1995). *An Integrative Model of Organizational Trust.* Academy of Management Review.

Cameron & Quinn's Competing Values Framework

Developers complain of heavy documentation procedures in a fast-paced environment (Hierarchy clash with Adhocracy) or lack of delivery focus in an operational scaling sprint (Clan clash with Market).



SCHEMATIC

Competing-values quadrant

T20

Cameron & Quinn's Competing Values Framework

MANAGER SCRIPT

Archetype Realignment

"Our delivery friction is caused by a misalignment of our operational modes. We are treating a critical uptime reliability phase (Hierarchy) with an exploratory prototype mentality (Adhocracy). For the next month, operational rigor, logging standards, and monitoring compliance take precedence over novel prototyping."

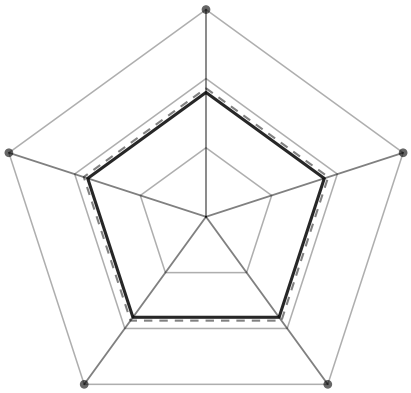
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Are runbooks, alerts and incident guides kept current?
- Was exploratory work held back during stabilization?

Source: Kim S. Cameron & Robert E. Quinn (1999). *Diagnosing and Changing Organizational Culture.* Addison-Wesley.

The SCARF Model (David Rock)

Developers react with hostility to sudden code reassignments (Autonomy threat), unexpected changes in team leadership (Certainty/Status threat), or uneven on-call shifts (Fairness threat).



SCHEMATIC

SCARF radar

T21

The SCARF Model (David Rock)

MANAGER SCRIPT

SCARF Threat Mitigation

"The upcoming architectural refactor introduces operational uncertainty. I want to emphasize our boundaries: every engineer retains complete Autonomy over implementation designs within their service. On-call rotations will be audited to ensure complete Fairness. Let's discuss where anyone feels their autonomy or technical continuity is constrained."

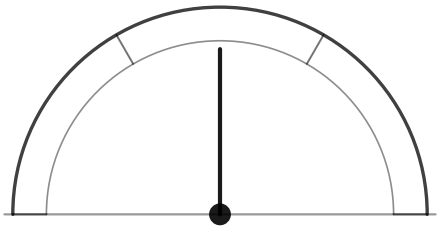
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did defensive replies to architecture feedback fall?
- Is the on-call rota seen as fair by juniors and seniors?

Source: David Rock (2008). *SCARF: A Brain-Based Model for Collaborating with and Influencing Others.* NeuroLeadership Journal.

Psychological Contract Theory (Denise Rousseau)

Sudden disengagement from an exceptional engineer; reluctance to participate in voluntary mentoring; abrupt shift from high commitment to "quiet quitting" or strict compliance with minimal requirements.



SCHEMATIC

Psychological-contract continuum

T22

Psychological Contract Theory (Denise Rousseau)

MANAGER SCRIPT

Contract Repair 1-on-1

"I have observed a shift in your energy over the past three sprints. Typically, this points to an unaddressed breach in our operating expectations—perhaps around career progression, technical ownership, or workload balancing. I want to uncover where our operational reality has diverged from your expectations."

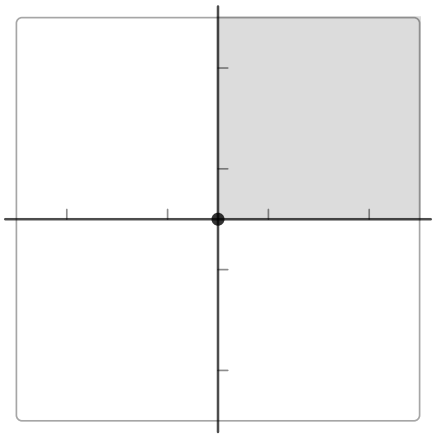
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Has the engineer re-joined roadmap and design discussions?
- Is there a written development plan restoring the balance?

Source: Denise M. Rousseau (1995). *Psychological Contracts in Organizations: Understanding Written and Unwritten Agreements.* Sage Publications.

Scott’s Radical Candor Matrix

Substandard, defect-ridden code is approved in pull requests without constructive commentary to avoid tension (Ruinous Empathy); or reviewers leave caustic, sarcastic remarks on junior contributions (Obnoxious Aggression).



SCHEMATIC

Care-and-challenge quadrant

T23

Scott’s Radical Candor Matrix

MANAGER SCRIPT

Ruinous Empathy Corrective

"In our team's PR reviews, I am observing Ruinous Empathy. We are approving pull requests with noticeable architectural and functional defects to keep interactions smooth. This is not kindness; it sets up production incidents and damages careers. Our standard is Radical Candor: we care personally about our peers' growth, which requires challenging their code directly."

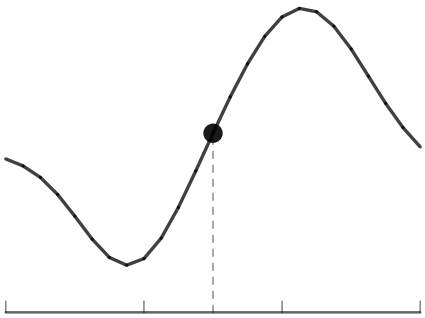
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do code reviews give detailed structural critique, framed constructively?
- Have defects slipping past review into staging fallen?

Source: Kim Scott (2017). *Radical Candor: Be a Kick-Ass Boss Without Losing Your Humanity.* St. Martin's Press.

Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) Feedback Framework

Managers provide vague, subjective feedback (e.g., "You have a negative attitude in planning" or "You are not a team player"), producing defensiveness, denial, and interpersonal hostility.



SCHEMATIC

Three-part feedback arc

T24

Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) Feedback Framework

MANAGER SCRIPT

SBI Feedback Delivery

"I want to share feedback regarding this morning's architectural sync. In that meeting (Situation), when Contributor X presented their caching proposal, you interrupted them three times and stated their solution was completely broken without providing data (Behavior). As a consequence, the proposal was abandoned, X disengaged, and the team lost forty minutes of constructive technical design (Impact)."

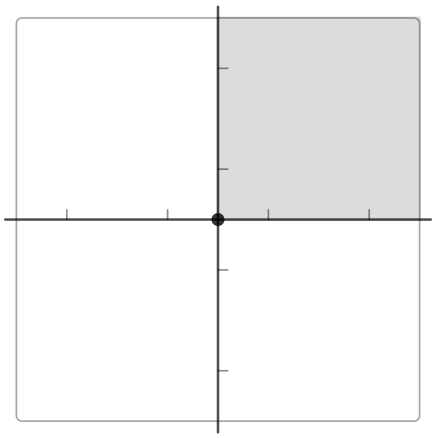
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the recipient change the targeted behavior in cross-team syncs?
- Do retrospectives use SBI, not personal attribution?

Developed by the Center for Creative Leadership; the source cites no originating publication.

Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument (TKI)

Over-reliance on Avoiding leads to unaddressed architecture issues; perpetual Competing turns every technical selection into an ideological war; habitual Accommodating produces brittle compromises.



SCHEMATIC

Conflict-mode quadrant

T25

Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument (TKI)

MANAGER SCRIPT

Conflict Mode Intervention

"Our technical debates around the data migration have stalled in an Avoidance loop. We are moving toward a Collaborating mode. We will list the architectural constraints of each option side-by-side, map them to our business SLAs, and build an integrated solution that addresses both scaling and deployment requirements."

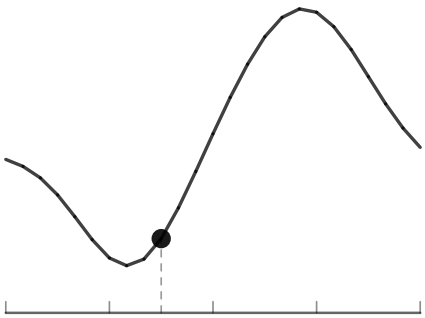
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Do technical conflicts become joint design workshops?
- Has the unaddressed Jira dispute backlog shrunk?

Source: Kenneth W. Thomas & Ralph H. Kilmann (1974). *Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Mode Instrument.* Xicom.

Rosenberg's Nonviolent Communication (NVC)

Sarcastic exchanges on Slack channels; hostile comments on code commits; finger-pointing during on-call incident escalations.



SCHEMATIC

Four-part request arc

T26

Rosenberg’s Nonviolent Communication (NVC)

MANAGER SCRIPT

NVC Facilitation

"When our staging build remains broken for three consecutive hours (Observation), the rest of the squad is blocked from testing and verifying their work (Impact). The team requires continuous integration reliability to maintain deployment velocity (Need). Can we agree that anyone whose commit breaks the main pipeline will prioritize reverting it within ten minutes? (Request)."

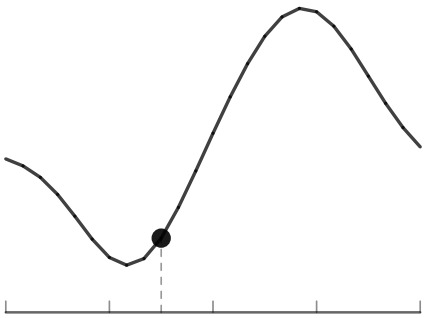
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Has time-to-revert for a broken main build dropped below fifteen minutes?
- Have accusatory channel messages become operational requests?

Source: Marshall B. Rosenberg (2003). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Life.* PuddleDancer Press.

Blameless Post-Mortems & Just Culture

Fear of deploying on Fridays; engineers withholding logs or timelines after an outage; production incident reviews focused on "who introduced the bug" rather than why the system allowed bad code through.



SCHEMATIC

Incident-review arc

T27

Blameless Post-Mortems & Just Culture

MANAGER SCRIPT

Blameless Framing

"We are convening the post-mortem for incident INC-4029. We operate from the fundamental premise: every engineer acted rationally based on the information and tools they had at the time. We will not discuss who ran the command or pushed the bad commit. We will determine why our automation and canary checks failed to catch this defect before customer impact."

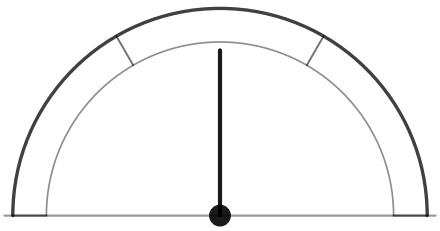
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the post-mortem produce automation or tests rather than manual checks?
- Was it published within forty-eight hours with no names attached?

Source: Sidney Dekker (2012). *Just Culture: Balancing Safety and Accountability.* Ashgate.
Source: John Allspaw (2012). *Blameless PostMortems and a Just Culture.* Etsy Code as Craft.

Crucial Conversations Framework

Sudden explosive arguments in meetings; silent disengagement followed by resignations; escalation of minor technical disagreements to executive leaders.



SCHEMATIC

Conversation-safety continuum

T28

Crucial Conversations Framework

MANAGER SCRIPT

Contrasting & Mutual Purpose

"I want to discuss the missed platform migration deadline. To be clear, my intent is not to question your technical ability or micromanage your work. My intent is to make sure we understand the architectural blockers so we can protect your time and hit our external commit dates. Can we review the work together?"

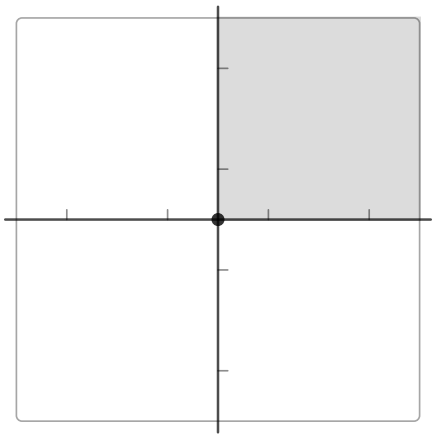
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Has the member surfaced schedule or technical risk unprompted?
- Have direct conversations replaced escalations to the manager?

Source: Kerry Patterson, Joseph Grenny, Ron McMillan & Al Switzler (2002). *Crucial Conversations: Tools for Talking When Stakes Are High.* McGraw-Hill.

The Johari Window for Interpersonal Transparency

Developers repeatedly making the same communication or technical mistakes without realizing it (Blind Spot); engineers suffering from imposter syndrome or burnout in silence (Hidden Area).



SCHEMATIC

Johari quadrant

T29

The Johari Window for Interpersonal Transparency

MANAGER SCRIPT

Blind Spot Feedback Solicitation

"To accelerate my effectiveness as an engineering manager, I need to expand my open window. What is one operational habit I exhibit in sprint planning that slows you down or introduces noise, which I might be blind to?"

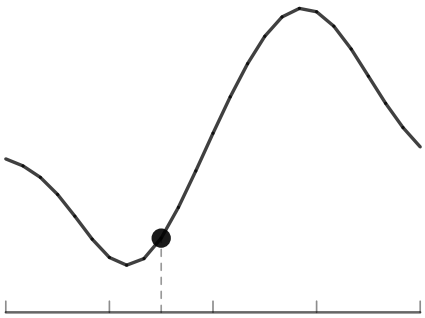
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did reports ask for feedback in their one-to-ones?
- Has the manager changed at least one process on team feedback?

Source: Joseph Luft & Harrington Ingham (1955). *The Johari Window, a Graphic Model of Interpersonal Awareness.* Proceedings of the Western Training Laboratory in Group Development.

Argyris’s Ladder of Inference & Double-Loop Learning

Engineers making hasty, negative assumptions about why another squad's API failed; doubling down on broken sprint plans rather than questioning underlying architecture assumptions.



SCHEMATIC

Ladder-of-inference arc

T30

Argyris's Ladder of Inference & Double-Loop Learning

MANAGER SCRIPT

Ladder Disassembly Inquiry

"We have made a rapid assumption that Team B deliberately broke our endpoint to accelerate their own sprint. Let us climb down the ladder of inference. What is the raw, observable data in the git commit log? What assumptions did we attach to that data? Let us speak with their tech lead before acting on that belief."

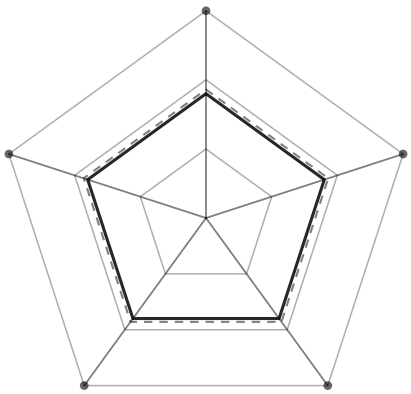
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did debugging meetings use telemetry rather than intent?
- Did retrospectives review core assumptions, not symptoms?

Source: Chris Argyris (1990). *Overcoming Organizational Defenses: Facilitating Organizational Learning*. Allyn and Bacon.

Fisher & Ury's Principled Negotiation

Deadlocked discussions between Product Management and Engineering regarding scope vs. speed; engineers refusing to compromise on non-critical architectural preferences.



SCHEMATIC

Negotiation-elements radar

T31

Fisher & Ury’s Principled Negotiation

MANAGER SCRIPT

Interests vs. Positions Realignment

"We are locked in positional bargaining: Product demands a release by the 15th, and Engineering demands an additional month for testing. Let us decouple people from the problem. Product's underlying interest is meeting a client commitment; Engineering's underlying interest is preventing data loss in production. What delivery options fulfill both interests simultaneously?"

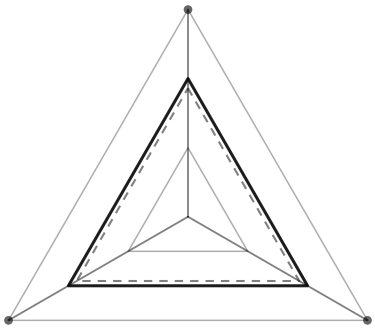
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Was the negotiated feature slice shipped on schedule with its agreed coverage?
- Did Product and Engineering agree an objective release-gating metric?

Source: Roger Fisher & William Ury (1981). *Getting to Yes: Negotiating Agreement Without Giving In.* Houghton Mifflin.

Stone & Heen's Feedback Triggers

An engineer rejects accurate technical critique because it was delivered by a colleague they dislike (Relationship Trigger), or enters a defensive spiral over a minor PR suggestion (Identity Trigger).



SCHEMATIC

Feedback-trigger radar

T32

Stone & Heen’s Feedback Triggers

MANAGER SCRIPT

Trigger Deconstruction

"When reviewing the feedback from the sprint retrospective, I noticed immediate pushback. Let us separate the message from the messenger. If we ignore who wrote this PR comment, is the technical critique regarding concurrency handling accurate? Let's analyze the technical merits of the code itself."

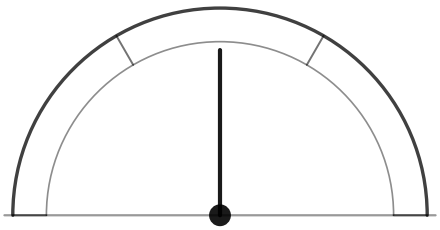
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the recipient merge the suggested technical changes?
- Are reviews about technical logic rather than reviewer seniority?

Source: Douglas Stone & Sheila Heen (2014). *Thanks for the Feedback: The Science and Art of Receiving Feedback Well.* Viking.

Lencioni’s Conflict Continuum

Meetings are calm and quiet, yet real disagreements are voiced afterward in backchannels; decisions made in team meetings are ignored or resisted passively.



SCHEMATIC

Conflict continuum

T33

Lencioni’s Conflict Continuum

MANAGER SCRIPT

Artificial Harmony Disruption

"This architectural direction affects every engineer on this squad, yet no one has raised a counter-argument. That tells me we are stuck in artificial harmony. I will not accept universal agreement on a complex distributed systems migration. What is the primary weakness in this proposal that we are actively avoiding?"

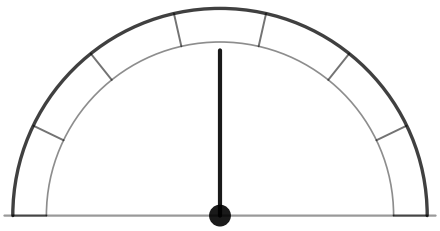
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did RFCs collect substantive dissent before approval?
- Have hallway complaints after meetings fallen to zero?

Source: Patrick Lencioni (2002). *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team: A Leadership Fable.* Jossey-Bass.

Delegation Poker & Seven Levels of Authority

An engineer escalates routine decisions to the manager out of caution; or conversely, an engineer deploys a breaking architectural change without team awareness or sign-off.



SCHEMATIC

Seven-level authority continuum

T34

Delegation Poker & Seven Levels of Authority

MANAGER SCRIPT

Delegation Clarity

"We have ambiguous authority boundaries regarding production database migrations. We will use the Seven Levels of Authority. For minor index updates, the authority level is Level 7: Delegate—execute without checking. For schema modifications, it is Level 4: Agree—we must come to a shared consensus. For core data migrations, it is Level 3: Consult—I will make the final decision after your input."

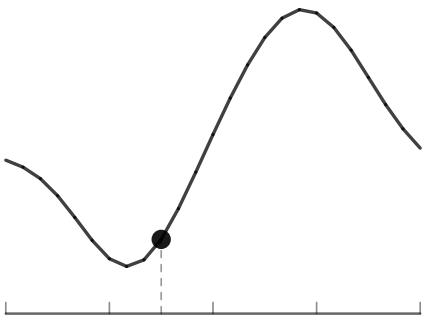
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the manager stay out of decisions at level five or above?
- Did engineers decide autonomously inside their agreed bounds?

Source: Jurgen Appelo (2011). *Management 3.0: Leading Agile Developers, Developing Agile Leaders.* Addison-Wesley.

Whitmore's GROW Coaching Model

Engineers enter 1-on-1s expecting the manager to solve their technical or team challenges; the manager becomes a bottleneck for tactical execution.



SCHEMATIC

GROW arc

T35

Whitmore’s GROW Coaching Model

MANAGER SCRIPT

Coaching Facilitation

"Let us walk through this blocker using the GROW framework. What is the specific operational outcome you want to see here? (Goal). What have you tried so far, and where is the technical barrier? (Current Reality). If access or legacy code constraints were removed, what solutions exist? (Options). What concrete step will you take by Friday? (Will)."

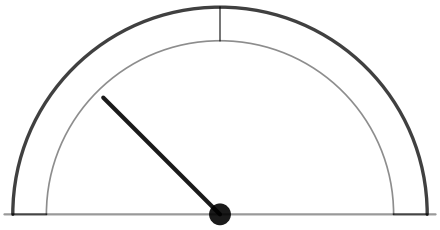
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the engineer carry out their own chosen solution unaided?
- Have that engineer's escalation requests fallen in later one-to-ones?

Source: John Whitmore (1992). *Coaching for Performance.* Nicholas Brealey.

Graham’s Maker vs. Manager Schedules

Engineers report low coding velocity despite high hours; commit graphs show activity only late at night; team members complain of fragmented attention caused by mid-morning or mid-afternoon syncs.



SCHEMATIC

Maker-to-manager continuum

T36

Graham’s Maker vs. Manager Schedules

MANAGER SCRIPT

Maker Schedule Protection

"Our engineering calendar shows fractured Maker schedules. Effective immediately, we are establishing uninterrupted focus blocks. Tuesdays and Thursdays will be zero-meeting days. All sync standups, 1-on-1s, and planning sessions are restricted to Monday and Wednesday mornings. Deep work time will be protected."

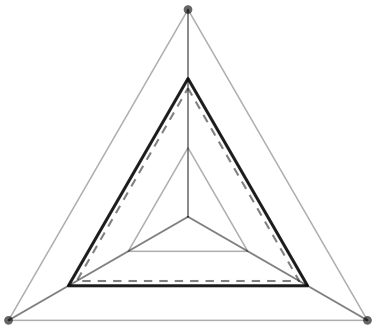
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did developers get uninterrupted focus blocks past four hours?
- Did commits move from late-night bursts to midday focus?

Source: Paul Graham (2009). *Maker's Schedule, Manager's Schedule.* paulgraham.com.

Cognitive Load Theory in Software Teams

Developers spend hours configuring local environments, dealing with flaky test suites, or chasing down complex deployment scripts; delivery of straightforward features takes weeks.



SCHEMATIC

Cognitive-load radar

T37

Cognitive Load Theory in Software Teams

MANAGER SCRIPT

Extraneous Load Reduction

"The time required to run our integration suite locally has become an extraneous cognitive burden. We are pausing new feature development for 72 hours. We will containerize the local dev setup and stabilize flaky integration tests to return our cognitive focus to building core product features."

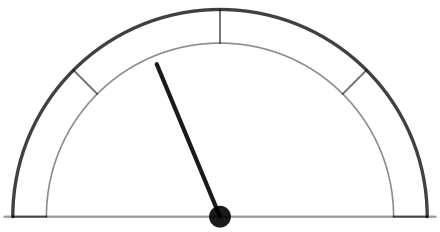
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did local test suite runtimes fall by more than half?
- Did cycle time from pull request to staging improve?

Source: John Sweller (1988). *Cognitive Load During Problem Solving: Effects on Learning.* Cognitive Science.
Source: Matthew Skelton & Manuel Pais (2019). *Team Topologies: Organizing Business and Technology Teams for Fast Flow.* IT Revolution Press.

Asynchronous Working Agreements & GitLab Remote Fluency

Decisions are made in undocumented ad-hoc video calls, leaving distributed or remote members misaligned; engineers are constantly interrupted by "@here" or "@channel" mentions on Slack.



SCHEMATIC

Synchronous-to-asynchronous continuum

T38

Asynchronous Working Agreements & GitLab Remote Fluency

MANAGER SCRIPT

Async-First Mandate

"We are spending excessive time in status syncs that could be handled asynchronously. Moving forward, synchronous meetings require a shared document with context and options linked twenty-four hours in advance. If a meeting lacks a documented agenda, it is automatically cancelled. Real-time meetings are reserved strictly for high-context debate and social connection."

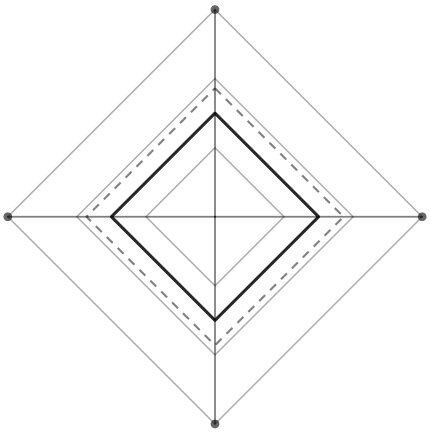
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did scheduled synchronous meeting time fall across the squad?
- Are decisions in versioned ADRs rather than Slack threads?

Source: Richard L. Daft & Robert H. Lengel (1986). *Organizational Information Requirements, Media Richness and Structural Design.* Management Science.
Source: GitLab (2024). *The GitLab Handbook.* GitLab Inc..

Loehr & Schwartz's Energy Management Audit

Engineers submitting low-quality pull requests with careless bugs late on Friday nights; team members showing chronic irritability in retrospectives; declining participation in sprint events.



SCHEMATIC

Four-domain energy radar

T39

Loehr & Schwartz's Energy Management Audit

MANAGER SCRIPT

Energy Depletion Check-In

"The team has operated under sustained deployment pressure for three straight iterations. Extended hours do not yield increased software quality; they produce fragile code and cognitive burnout. We are running an operational energy audit. Each person will identify one non-essential operational obligation to drop this sprint. High-severity on-call pages will trigger immediate compensatory time off."

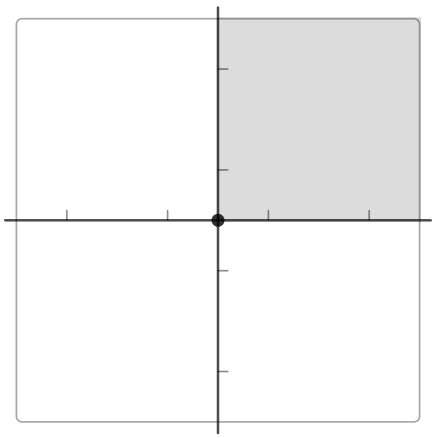
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Were after-hours pull requests and on-call alerts reduced?
- Did engineers take compensatory rest after severe incidents?

Source: Jim Loehr & Tony Schwartz (2003). *The Power of Full Engagement.* The Free Press.

Cynefin Framework for Operational Decision Making

Leaders demand detailed, six-month predictive roadmaps for emergent, exploratory research projects (treating Complex as Complicated); teams run open-ended brainstorms in the middle of a critical outage (treating Chaotic as Complex).



SCHEMATIC

Four-domain decision quadrant

T40

Cynefin Framework for Operational Decision Making

MANAGER SCRIPT

Context-Domain Alignment

"We are debating this research spike using the wrong operational mindset. This is not a Complicated domain where an expert can predict the ideal architecture in advance; it is a Complex domain. We cannot plan our way through it upfront. We will launch three lightweight spikes this week, probe system responses, and let the architecture emerge from live telemetry."

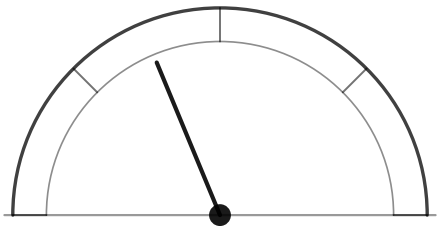
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the team run quick spikes before choosing the architecture?
- Were outages handled decisively without consensus meetings?

Source: David J. Snowden & Mary E. Boone (2007). *A Leader's Framework for Decision Making*. Harvard Business Review.

Hersey-Blanchard Situational Leadership Theory (SLII)

A senior engineer feels micromanaged when given step-by-step task instructions (Directing applied to D4); a new junior engineer feels abandoned and overwhelmed when told to "just figure out" a complex codebase (Delegating applied to D1).



SCHEMATIC

Four-style leadership continuum

T41

Hersey-Blanchard Situational Leadership Theory (SLII)

MANAGER SCRIPT

Situational Style Calibration

"You are tackling our distributed event pipeline, which is a new domain for you (D1/D2). I will not leave you to navigate this alone, nor will I take over the keyboard. For the first two sprints, we will use a Directing-Coaching cadence: we will pair daily on architecture reviews and outline explicit task parameters until you feel confident in the codebase."

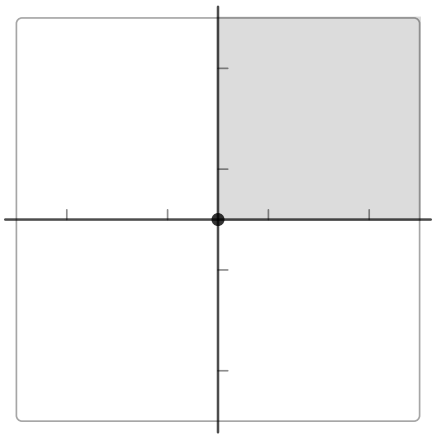
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Has the junior engineer shipped clean pull requests unaided?
- Has the senior kept technical ownership without micromanagement?

Source: Paul Hersey & Kenneth H. Blanchard (1969). *Life Cycle Theory of Leadership.* Training and Development Journal.

Eisenhower Matrix for Technical Debt Prioritization

The engineering team spends its sprints responding to immediate firefighting, alerts, and Slack messages; foundational refactoring and system improvements are neglected for quarters at a time.



SCHEMATIC

Urgency-and-importance quadrant

T42

Eisenhower Matrix for Technical Debt Prioritization

MANAGER SCRIPT

Quadrant II Reclamation

"Our sprints have been consumed by urgent operational firefighting (Quadrant I and III) at the expense of core system resilience (Quadrant II). We will reserve 20% of every sprint's capacity exclusively for non-urgent, high-importance engineering work: addressing structural technical debt, automating test suites, and refining deployment pipelines."

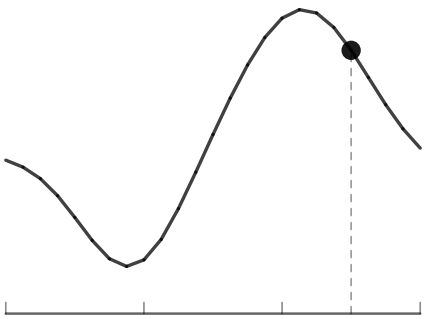
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Was twenty percent of sprint capacity spent on stabilization?
- Did urgent production alerts fall after the refactoring?

Source: Stephen R. Covey (1989). *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People.* The Free Press.

Grove & Doerr's OKR Cascading Framework

Engineers deliver dozens of tickets without understanding their business impact; teams celebrate hitting output milestones while core product metrics remain stagnant.



SCHEMATIC

Three-level cascade arc

T43

Grove & Doerr’s OKR Cascading Framework

MANAGER SCRIPT

Outcome Over Output Alignment

"Our sprint delivery shows high output, but our business impact is flat. Completing eight Jira tickets is an output; reducing checkout latency by 150 milliseconds is an outcome. We are defining our team OKRs around quantitative outcomes. If a deliverable does not move our key result metric, it will not enter the sprint backlog."

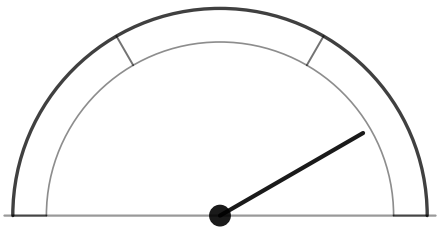
DAY-14 CHECKS

- Can each contributor name the metric their pull request moves?
- Did the squad prune backlog items that map to no OKR?

Source: Andrew S. Grove (1983). *High Output Management.* Random House.
Source: John Doerr (2018). *Measure What Matters.* Portfolio/ Penguin.

Spotify Cadence & Decoupled Deployments

Teams are blocked waiting for other squads to test or approve code; multiple squads attempt massive, simultaneous end-of-quarter deployments that fail in production.



SCHEMATIC

Cadence continuum

T44

Spotify Cadence & Decoupled Deployments

MANAGER SCRIPT

Cadence Decoupling

"Our release cycle is stalled because four teams are synchronizing deployments on the same date. We are separating release cadence from code deployments. Squads will use feature flags and well-defined API boundaries to deploy to production independently. We will sync asynchronously across chapters on shared interface contracts."

DAY-14 CHECKS

- Did the squad deploy to production without a release train?
- Are dependencies handled with feature flags and versioned APIs?

Source: Henrik Kniberg & Anders Ivarsson (2012). *Scaling Agile @ Spotify with Tribes, Squads, Chapters & Guilds.* Crisp.